

THE YOUTH'S COMPANION

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No. 41 TEMPLE PLACE.

For the Companion.

A KERNEL OF CORN.

My story is about a kernel of corn. But that one kernel of corn was the cause of a serious dispute, and gave rise to several questions of honor and fair dealing which I hope the reader will be able to settle satisfactorily in his own mind.

The kernel of corn may be said to be a historic one. It was the ancestor of that variety of field corn once well known, locally, at least, as the "red Indian corn,"—something as now we have the "pine-knot" corn, the "yellow flint," and the "Compton," and the "lost nation wheat."

As I have said, it had a curious history, of which the following are the points of interest.

So far as is known, its origin was on the farm of a man named Carroll, whose place joined that where the present writer lived when young.

Jim and Ed Carroll were boy neighbors, and up to the time of my story, were very intimate with my brother Thomas and myself.

That season, Mr. Carroll had a two-acre field of "peach-blow" potatoes just below our line-wall, on the west side of the road; and I well remember how beautifully they looked when in blossom. People never seem to look for any beauty in a potato-field; yet I know of few more beautiful sights than a large field of peach-blow or early rose potatoes in full bloom.

When hoeing-potato time came, Tom and I changed works, as we called it, with the Carroll boys; that is to say, for the sake of working together, we worked for them one day, and they for us the next.

Potatoes, as every farm boy knows, have to be "hilled up." We used to work two to a row, one hilling up one side of it, the other following him and hilling up the other side. The four of us could thus carry two rows along at once, and that almost as fast as one could walk, after they had been cultivated out.

One forenoon, as we hoed together in Mr. Carroll's two-acre field, Ed and I came to a fine, fresh shoot of corn standing alone between two potato-hills in our row.

"Seems too bad to cut it up," Ed said, "it looks so green and nice. Let it grow with the potatoes if it will."

We pulled out the weeds round it, hilled it up a little, and let it stand. That a kernel of common corn had found its way into the field here and germinated, was no great wonder. But this was not common corn, though we did not then know to the contrary.

It grew rankly, and was soon visible a long way off, among the low potatoes. In August, it stood a tall, strong stalk, seven feet in height, with remarkably fine, broad leaves, and a bushy tassel, rich in pollen. Two fine ears had formed on it.

By the 8th of September, the husk cracked, disclosing the corn, now fully turned from the milk. It still stood erect in the field, and when the boys came to dig the potatoes, we noticed it more particularly.

For, instead of being a golden yellow, like the common eight-rowed corn planted thereabouts, this corn was of a deep, reddish tint, and ten-rowed. The ears, too, were very large, fully a foot in length, and very finely formed. The kernels were evenly set in the rows along the cob, and handsomely shaped. In fact, as every one who saw it said, they were two of the handsomest ears of corn ever raised in that region.

Mr. Carroll told the boys to let the stalk stand till the corn was fully ripened, so as to save it for seed. Many visitors and all the neighboring farmers went to look at it. No one seeing it knew to what variety it belonged; and many were the speculations as to how it got there.

Some thought it was a stray kernel left in the soil and somehow preserved down from the days when the Indians used to plant corn there; and partly from that conjecture, and partly from its red color, it got the name of red Indian corn. Others thought that some passing crow or jay might have dropped it—having brought it from a great distance. But nobody knew.

About the middle of September, while the stalk stood out there, now quite ripened, a thievish cosset-sheep got out of the cow-pasture into the field, and going along, pulled down the stalk and ate both ears. The boys did not see the old creature till just as she was munching off the last kernels.

Then they ran at full speed, but were too late,

The matter made a sad breach in our hitherto friendly relations. The heads of the two families took no notice of the quarrel; but we boys did not speak to each other for over a year. We grew thoroughly imbibed,—all the more so that we had formerly been so intimate.

But worse difficulties followed.

Next spring, Jim and Ed planted the seven

cobs, on the stalks, and gone: nor was there a track, or a trace, to indicate the character of the robber. Probably two more angry boys could not have been found in the whole State.

The next thing, in fact the first thing, Tom and I heard, was that Jim and Ed had charged us with taking the corn; that they had called us thieves in public. All the neighboring boys were talking of the matter.

We felt outraged. To call a boy a *thief* is decidedly worse than calling him a *hog*. We knew no more than they what had become of their corn. Even our parents were, I think, a little offended about the charge: for no father likes to have his son called a thief. I remember our folks asked us about it, and that, finding Tom and I really knew nothing about the corn, father bade us keep very quiet and make no threats, saying that the truth might ere long come out.

October and the greater part of November passed. The days had now grown very short, and the weather was biting cold. But snow had not yet come; and one afternoon which had been rather more sunny, father had set Tom and me to grubbing up some sumachs in the east field. We made a pile of these, ready for burning.

Down next the line-wall there had lain, on our side, an old red-oak log, for some years.

This oak had stood nearly on the line, and had been felled because it shaded so much tillage ground. The trunk had been left lying where it fell. But it was now a good deal decayed. Father bade us take the oxen and drag it up to our pile. This we did just at sunset; and then set to work to split it up, in order to throw it on the brush-pile, to burn.

We had been pounding away at it for some minutes, when there suddenly darted out of a hole in the end a little striped squirrel, or "chipmunk." The little creature, rudely awakened from his winter torpor, by our heavy blows, took refuge in a near stone-pile.

We supposed it might have a nest inside the old log. But we were hardly prepared for the sight that met our eyes when at last we got the log open; for there, inside it, nicely packed in punk, together with fully half a peck of wheat, was *that red corn*,—nearly a quart,—every kernel of it, I dare say!

We shouted.

Then we called father.

He laughed well.

"Don't touch it," said he.

Then he called Mabel, our little sister, and bade her run down to "neighbor Carroll's," and ask him and the boys to come up as quickly as they could.

On our stepping back from the log for a few minutes, the poor chilly little squirrel ran from the cold stone-pile back into his nest, with a faint little chuckle. So that when Mr. Carroll and the boys came up, the innocent little robber was trying to cuddle himself into the punk, but still in plain sight.

Tom just pointed to the log and said,—

"There's the corn *we stole from you!*"

They saw how it was in a minute; and certainly looked anything but comfortable; even Mr. Carroll, himself, looked down and seemed far from easy.

At length Jim stepped up to the log, as if to take the corn.

"Hold on there!" said Tom and I. "That's ours now. A crow or a squirrel dropped that first kernel just over the line, on your side. It was yours then. But you were too stingy to give us one kernel. Now a squirrel has brought it to our side of the line and put it in our log. So now we'll keep it."

But father laughed and said,—

"I guess half and half is fair."

"Fair enough," said Mr. Carroll. "And boys!" he exclaimed, rather angrily, to Jim and Ed, "you've been to blame in this. I declare for it, if I ain't ashamed of ye! and I don't ever want to hear another word about this silly grudge; and I hope neighbor Edmund's boys will overlook it in ye!"

We overlooked the ugly word *thief*,—which no



A KERNEL OF CORN.

kernels with great care. They could not put it in their garden, lest it should mix with the sweet corn, nor yet out in the field on the west side of the road, where the ordinary corn was. So they reserved a little plot, about a rod square, in the wheat-field on the east side of the road, up next to the line-wall. This plot they dressed richly, and planted the seven kernels in three hills. It was a warm, sheltered spot.

But just as the shoots were breaking the ground, the crows, or one crow, lit down on the plot, one Sunday morning before breakfast, and pulled up all but two of the spears, which were just breaking ground.

My brother and I were made aware of this disaster next morning by seeing Jim and Ed putting up a horrible "scarecrow" in the plot; and I fear we were not very sorry on account of it.

The two remaining kernels, however, came up and grew with the same vigor and strength which had marked the growth of the stalk among the potatoes.

Tom and I often watched them from our side of the line-wall. Later in the season, Jim and Ed set stakes about them, to support them in case of a violent shower. Both stalks matured and had each two fine large ears.

From August till into September, the boys used to come out every day to see that the corn had not been molested. Already the shuck had begun to crack off from the ears, showing the rich dark red tint.

One morning near the 12th of September, they went out and found every kernel shelled off the

cannon, was safely back in New York State. Leaving his military escort to bring on the guns, the artillery set off at full speed to carry the news to Gen. Washington. That night, a storm overtook him, and he lodged in a log-cabin, the farmer and his wife and children occupying the bed, while he slept in his blanket before the kitchen fire. After midnight, another knock was heard, and he rose to admit another belated traveller, a young man with a handsome, ingenuous, but somewhat weak countenance.

"The two lay down on the hearth together, and becoming interested in each other, conversed until nearly daylight. At dawn, they parted, going in different directions. They did not meet again until 1780. The artillery was Maj. Gen. Henry Knox, and he took part in the trial of the other, Maj. John Andre, who was hung as a spy."

Commodore Marsden heard the story from Admiral Paulding, whose father aided in the arrest of Andre, and also from the son of Knox, who had frequently heard his father narrate it.



INDIANS' LOVE FOR THEIR CHILDREN.

A year or two ago, the daughter of an Indian chief, who had been educated in New York, returned to the Reservation as a teacher. The tribe were roused to envy when they saw one of their own number thus made, to all appearance, the equal of the whites.

The Indians are passionately fond of their children; and in every wigwam, fathers and mothers schemed how they should gain like advantages for their boys and girls. Just at this time, the proprietor of a travelling circus visited the Reservation with his miserable worn-out horses and performers, and being struck by the bright, eager face and fearless riding of a young girl of fourteen, went to her father and offered to educate her in the East and send her home a lady if he would allow her to go with him.

The credulous Indian consented. The circus started in the night, and the girl went with it. It was two days before the story reached the agent and missionary, who sent for the girl's father, and told him how he had been duped by the showman, whose purpose was undoubtedly to train her for the ring. The Indian stood silent for a moment; then, raising both hands to heaven, he cried,—

"O God, visit not my ignorance on my child!"

Without another word, he started in pursuit. He had no horse, nor money to pay his fare on the railway. He travelled four hundred miles on foot before he recovered his child, uninjured, though worn to a skeleton from exhaustion and hunger.

We, to whom education, as a rule, comes as freely as air or sunshine, can have little conception of the hungry despair with which these copper-colored brothers in Indian wigwams covet the opportunity which we hold so cheaply. There is no sight more pathetic than a human being struggling vainly for that knowledge which will make a man of it instead of a brute.

An Omaha teacher tells us that the children of that tribe came last winter to school, walking from two to six miles. The hunt last year failed, and they had no moccasins. Their bare feet marked their way on the ice and snow with bloody prints.

How many white children would do this of their own accord? Two schools at the East are now open to Indian children under the care of the Government, one at Carlisle, Pa., and the Industrial Training School at Hampton, Va. It is the object of the Government to send back these educated youths as teachers to civilize and elevate their tribes.

GREAT WORKS IN OLDEN TIMES.

Wendell Phillips thinks the ancients attained perfection in some arts, the knowledge of which has been lost in our time. It is certain that those most familiar with steam-power and modern machinery are puzzled to explain how the grand structures of the ancient world were erected. Builders say that no modern contractor could erect the great pyramid in Egypt, and lift the gigantic stones at the summit to the height of four hundred and fifty feet.

A recent visitor to Baalbec, and the ruins of the great temple of Baal, doubts if any modern architect could rebuild the temple in its ancient grandeur. Three huge stones, sixty-four feet long, thirteen high, and thirteen wide, stand in a wall at the height of twenty feet. Nine other stones, thirty feet long, ten high, and ten wide, are joined together with such nicety that a trained eye cannot discover the line of juncture.

A column still stands in the quarry, a mile distant, which is completed, with the exception that it is not detached at the bottom. It is sixty-nine feet long, seventeen high, and fourteen broad, and one cannot understand how it can be separated at the bottom from the quarry without breaking. The ruins of this vast temple inspire respect for the genius of former ages.

FUNERALS IN FRANCE.

There is one French custom we should like to see introduced into the United States, and become universal.

In France, when a funeral passes, every man raises his hat to salute it. The deceased person may have been a child, a pauper, a beggar; it is no matter; the cortege is saluted by every man, whether he be prince, millionaire, or mendicant. It is a good and lovely custom.

Few things are more humiliating than to see a funeral trotting down Broadway, in New York, winding in and out among the vehicles and other obstructions, exciting no more remark or attention than if it were a procession of old hacks going to the repair shops. In New York, the rapid pace seems unavoidable, owing to the great distance to the cemeteries. Elsewhere, funerals at least move with a decent slowness, and the evident sorrow of the followers seems to plead to the passer-by for some sympathetic recognition. It were a mark of civilization in us to bestow it upon them.

A FEMALE CRUSOE.

If De Foe had only known of a female Crusoe living on an ocean island, he might, perhaps, have wrought out a story superior to his Robinson Crusoe. Alexander Selkirk's brief life on Juan Fernandez

was trivial, either in the hardships endured or the difficulties conquered, compared with that of a native woman on an island opposite Southern California.

The Catholic Fathers at South Barbara were transporting the natives of the Island St. Nicholas to the mainland. Among them was a mother who discovered that her babe had been left behind. She begged that the ship might be put back, but the captain refused. She leaped into the sea to swim ashore, but, as a storm prevailed, they all thought she was drowned.

Eighteen years after, a company landed on the island. They found traces of life, and after long search discovered the woman, and took her with them. The poor mother never found her babe, but had managed to live in comparative comfort, though very lonely. After her long life chiefly in the open air, she could not bear the confinement of a house, and soon sickened and died.

NOT A BRUTE.

The eloquent John B. Gough, combating the idea that drunkards are brutes whom it is useless to try to reform, tells the following pathetic story:

"I once picked up a man in the market-place. They said, 'He is a brute; let him alone.' I took him home with me, and kept the 'brute' fourteen days and nights, through his delirium; and he nearly frightened my wife out of her wits, one night, chasing her all about the house with a boot in his hand; but she recovered her wits, and he recovered his."

He said to me, "You wouldn't think I had a wife and child?"

"Well, I shouldn't."

"I have, and—God bless her little heart—my little Mary is as pretty a little thing as ever yet stepped!" said the brute.

I asked, "Where do they live?"

"They live two miles away from here."

"When did you see them last?"

"About two years ago." Then he told me his sad story.

I said, "You must go back again."

"I mustn't go back—I won't—my wife is better without me than with me! I will not go back any more. I have knocked her, and kicked her, and abused her. Do you suppose I will ever go back again?"

I went to the house with him. I knocked at the door, and the wife opened it. "Is this Mrs. Richardson?"

"Yes, sir."

"Well, that is Mr. Richardson. And Mr. Richardson, this is Mrs. Richardson. Now come into the house."

They went in. The wife sat on one side of the room and the brute on the other. I waited to see who would speak first, and it was the woman.

He had a large handkerchief around his neck, and she said, "You had better take the handkerchief off, William; you'll need it when you go out."

He began to fumble about it. The knot was large enough; he could have untied it if he liked, but he said, "Will you untie it, Mary?"

And she worked away at it; but her fingers were clumsy, and she couldn't get it off; their eyes met, and the love-light was not all quenched; she turned her arms gently, and he fell into them.

If you had seen those white arms clasped about his neck, and he sobbing on her breast, and the child looking in wonder first at one and then the other, you would have said, "It is not a brute; it is a man with a great, big, warm heart in his breast."

IN A DILEMMA.

Writers of fiction are sometimes much perplexed as to what they shall do with their heroes and heroines. While Dickens was writing "Dombey & Son,"—it was originally published as a serial, he received many letters begging him not to kill little Paul. But an astute critic remarked, "If Dickens don't kill Paul, Paul will kill Dickens." The novelist was of the same opinion, and, as our readers may remember, his description of little Paul's death is one of the most pathetic scenes in the novelist's works. The London *Truth* tells how another was once bothered by his heroine:

I used to know the late G. P. R. James, whose novels at one time enjoyed a very large circulation. One day I called upon him, as we had agreed to go out somewhere together. I found him dolefully seated over a manuscript.

He was not writing, but he was gazing at it with melancholy despair. I thought that he was ill, and asked him whether this was the case. No, he said, he was physically well. What, then, was the matter with him? I anxiously inquired.

"It is my heroine," he answered. "I have got her in such a fix that I cannot extricate her without a slight violation of the rules of propriety."

"Then let her be improper, and don't let us be late for the train," I flippantly said.

"My dear friend," he replied, "do you want to ruin me? Are you not aware that I live by never allowing my heroines to do anything to which the most stringent mamma might object? If once the slightest doubt were raised about my novels being sound reading for the most innocent of school-girls, my occupation would be gone."

And so we missed the train, but the heroine emerged from the pages of the novel a model of all that a heroine ought to do under difficult circumstances.

LAWYERS' FEES.

"What is the first thing you would do, if retained to bring a suit?" asked an examiner of an applicant for a license to practise law. "Get my fee," was the prompt reply which passed him. The spirit of the reply was once acted upon by a New York lawyer.

"Give me your opinion on this bill; is it a good one?" said a gentleman, holding out a five-dollar bank note.

The lawyer, after carefully examining it, said, "Yes, it is a good bill," and put it in his pocket.

"Thank you," said the gentleman; "and now I'll trouble you for that V."

"Oh no; I never give an opinion under five dollars." Two lawyers were employed to bring a suit for trespass. After a tedious trial, the jury gave a verdict for forty-five dollars. Each of the lawyers took twenty dollars, and gave five dollars to their client, who complained that they had eaten the turkey, and left him the bones to pick.

A GRANDMOTHER'S LOVE.

A beautiful story of a heart sublime in the strength and magnitude of the renunciation of self is thus recorded in one account of the disaster to the steamer *Narragansett*:

An old lady, Margaret Muir, of Brooklyn, about sixty years of age, was picked up while floating in the water, holding high above her infant grandchild, fifteen months old. She besought the men in the boat which came to her rescue to save the child at all hazards, saying,—

"Oh, for God's sake save the baby! Don't mind me! I am an old woman, whose life is of no account! I'm done for anyway. Save the baby, and if there's room for me, I'll come too."

Both she and the baby were rescued.

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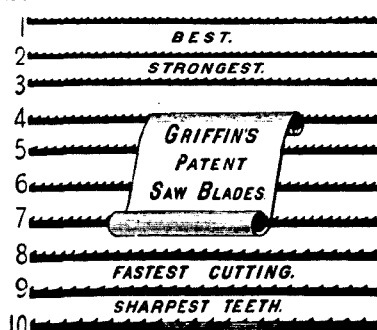
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SALEM STATION, FAUQUIER CO., VA., June 7th, 1880.

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was trivial, either in the hardships endured or the difficulties conquered, compared with that of a native woman on an island opposite Southern California.

The Catholic Fathers at South Barbara were transporting the natives of the Island St. Nicholas to the mainland. Among them was a mother who discovered that her babe had been left behind. She begged that the ship might be put back, but the captain refused. She leaped into the sea to swim ashore, but, as a storm prevailed, they all thought she was drowned.

Eighteen years after, a company landed on the island. They found traces of life, and after long search discovered the woman, and took her with them. The poor mother never found her babe, but had managed to live in comparative comfort, though very lonely. After her long life chiefly in the open air, she could not bear the confinement of a house, and soon sickened and died.

